

some money, and I leased a quote terminal for my apartment. I spent many days watching every tick in certain markets and doing point and figure charts, in addition to my daily charts, instead of attending class. The results weren't so good. I made every rookie mistake in the books. Rather than taking the easy route and trading with the trend, I was trying to pick tops and bottoms, and I sat with losers and took small profits.

Losing money is what got me hooked. I had heard that allegedly 90 percent of the traders in the futures markets lost money, but I was determined to be in the 10 percent. I was an excellent student, easily in the top 10 percent, and I often set the curve on exams. Whenever I took a test, my attitude was that someone had to make the highest grade on the curve, and that it might as well be me. And it often was. So being in the 90 percent that lost money in trading was not acceptable. I didn't graduate college because I became so engrossed in futures trading that I had no interest in engineering anymore.

At what point did you drop out?

In my senior year. I had nine credits left to finish.

I find that hard to understand. It seems like it would have been such a trivial matter to finish college.

I am not saying I did the right thing, although in retrospect, it turned out okay.

Do you ever regret coming so close to graduating college and not finishing?

I never look back, although sometimes it can be embarrassing. Whenever prospective investors conduct their due diligence and ask where I graduated, I have to explain that I went to college for four years and had a high 3.9 GPA, but didn't graduate.

What was your plan?

My plan was to go to Chicago, start in the pits, and learn how this business worked from the bottom up. I initially got a job as a phone clerk at the Chicago Mercantile Exchange. After a few months, it became apparent that there was no future on the floor unless you were in the pits. I got a job as a commodity broker.